

أَعُوذُ بِاللَّهِ مِنَ الشَّيْطَانِ الرَّجِيمِ

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Lisan ul Quran — Lecture 4

The gender of the Ism · Mudhakkar and Mu'annath

1. The four aspects of an Ism

Four things must be known about any *Ism* used in Arabic. Without them the word can neither be understood nor placed in a sentence.

Aspect	What it means	Its forms
Gender (Jins)	Whether the Ism is Mudhakkar or Mu'annath	Mudhakkar , Mu'annath
Number ('Adad)	Whether the Ism is Wahid, Tathniyah or Jam'	Wahid , Tathniyah , Jam'
Definiteness (Wus'at)	Whether the Ism is Ma'rifah or Nakirah	Ma'rifah , Nakirah
I'raab	The place the Ism occupies in a sentence or construction	Marfoo' , Mansoob , Majroor

This lecture deals with the first of the four, *the gender of the Ism*.

2. The gender of the Ism

Arabic has two genders: *Mudhakkar* and *Mu'annath*.

Gender	Definition	Examples
Mudhakkar	An Ism in which no mark of ta'neeth is found	أُسْتَاذٌ ، مُعَلِّمٌ ، مُسْلِمٌ
Mu'annath	An Ism in which some mark of ta'neeth is found	أُسْتَاذَةٌ ، مُعَلِّمَةٌ ، مُسْلِمَةٌ

The governing principle: In Arabic every *Ism* is taken to be *Mudhakkar* until it is established as *Mu'annath*. Being masculine is the default; being feminine is the departure from it, and a departure needs evidence or a mark.

The mark may be present in the word or only underlying it

The definition of *Mu'annath* includes that the mark of *ta'neeth* may be present *lafzan* (in the word itself) or *taqdeeran* (underlying it). *Lafzan* means the mark is visible, as in مُسَلِّمَةٌ.

Taqdeeran means it is not visible yet lies in the root of the word, as in أَرْضٌ — no mark of *ta'neeth* appears in it, but when its diminutive is formed it becomes أَرْضِيَّةٌ, and the round ة surfaces. This shows the mark was there all along.

3. Real and unreal gender

Living creatures that exist as male and female pairs have real gender, so such nouns are given one and the same gender in every language of the world. The word for boy is masculine in every language, and the word for girl is feminine in every language.

Lifeless things, however, have unreal gender, so different languages assign them different genders. This is exactly where an Urdu-speaking student most often errs, by carrying Urdu gender over into Arabic.

Feminine in Urdu, Mudhakkar in Arabic	Masculine in Urdu, Mu'annath in Arabic
كِتَابٌ (book)	الْمَدِينَةُ (Madinah)
مَسْجِدٌ (mosque)	غُرْفَةٌ (room)
جِدَارٌ (wall)	يَدٌ (hand) , سَمَاءٌ (sky)

4. The categories of the Mu'annath

The *Mu'annath* is of two kinds: *Mu'annath Haqeeqi* (real) and *Mu'annath Ghayr Haqeeqi* (unreal).

4.1 Mu'annath Haqeeqi

A feminine noun that has a masculine counterpart is a *Mu'annath Haqeeqi*. What is understood among living creatures as being female is, in Arabic, called *Mu'annath Haqeeqi*. Such a noun is treated as feminine in every language.

Mu'annath	Its Mudhakkar
إِمْرَأَةٌ (woman)	رَجُلٌ (man)
أُخْتُ (sister)	أَخٌ (brother)
نَاقَةٌ (she-camel)	جَمَلٌ (camel)

Three kinds of noun fall under the *Mu'annath Haqeeqi*:

- Nouns that have a masculine counterpart, as in **إِمْرَأَة** and **أَخْت**
- Women's names, as in **أَسْمَاءُ ، حُسَيْنِي ، فَاطِمَةُ ، مَرْيَمُ**
- Nouns used only for women, as in **أُمُّ** (mother), **ابْنَة** (daughter) and **مُرْضِع** (wet nurse)

Worth noting: Qualities that belong to women alone do not take a mark of *ta'neeth* at all, yet they are still counted as feminine, as in **حَائِض** and **حَامِل**. The round **ة** is not added to them because there is no possibility of their being masculine.

4.2 Mu'annath Ghayr Haqeeqi

Nouns that are simply used as feminine are called *Mu'annath Ghayr Haqeeqi*. Three names are given to this class, each for its own reason:

- *Ghayr Haqeeqi* — because such nouns are not in reality female.
- *Majazi* — because they are not feminine in origin but are used as feminine figuratively.
- *Lafzi* — because they are counted feminine by the make-up of the word.

The *Mu'annath Ghayr Haqeeqi* divides again into two: '*Alamati Mu'annath* (marked) and *Sama'i Mu'annath* (heard). In terminology the marked one is also called *Mu'annath Qiyasi*, because it is known by a fixed rule, whereas the *Sama'i* is known only from the usage of native speakers.

5. The 'Alamati (Qiyasi) Mu'annath and the marks of ta'neeth

An '*Alamati Mu'annath* is a noun in which some mark of the feminine is found. There are three marks of *ta'neeth*: the *Taa' Marbutah*, the *Alif Mamdudah* and the *Alif Maqsurah*.

5.1 Taa' Marbutah (ة)

The greatest mark of a feminine noun in Arabic is the round **ة**. Nearly ninety-nine percent of feminine nouns carry this mark, which makes it by far the most frequent, as in **مُسْلِمَة ، جَمِيلَة ، وَرْدَة**.

Word	Explanation
جَنَّة	Feminine, and in Urdu a garden is feminine too.
غُرْفَة	Feminine, whereas in Urdu the word for room is masculine.
آيَة	Feminine, and feminine in Urdu as well.

Exceptions: Some words carry a round ة at the end yet are used for males, such as حَذِيفَةٌ, طَلْحَةٌ and أُسَامَةٌ (all men's names), and likewise عَلَامَةٌ and خَلِيفَةٌ (both titles of men). All of them end in a round ة, yet in usage they are masculine.

5.2 A necessary foundation: Huroof Asliyyah

To grasp the next two marks, the idea of *Huroof Asliyyah* must be understood first. About **ninety percent** of Arabic nouns are built on just three of the *Huroof ul Hijaa'*. These three are called the *Huroof Asliyyah* or *Huroof ul Maddah*. Some nouns carry extra letters besides these three, but the base remains three.

Word	Letters visible	Huroof Asliyyah
زَيْدٌ	ز ي د	ز ي د
صَالِحٌ	ص ا ل ح	ص ل ح
مُنَافِقٌ	م ن ا ف ق	ن ف ق

5.3 Alif Mamdudah

The *Alif Mamdudah* and the *Alif Maqsurah* are together called the *Alif ut Ta'neeth* in grammatical terminology.

Rule: When an *Alif Mamdudah* comes at the end of a noun and its final hamzah is not one of the *Huroof Asliyyah*, the noun is counted feminine. The condition is that the *Alif Mamdudah* must be additional, not part of the root, and its hamzah must not be a substitute for a waw or a yaa'.

In the words below the *Alif Mamdudah* is additional and not part of the root, so all of them are feminine:

Word	Huroof Asliyyah	Meaning
صَحْرَاءُ	ص ح ر	desert
صَفْرَاءُ	ص ف ر	yellow
بُكَمَاءُ	ب ك م	mute (f.)

But not every *Alif Mamdudah* is a mark of the feminine. In Arabic a hamzah often stands in place of a waw or a yaa', and if the final hamzah belongs to the root, the *Alif Mamdudah* is not a mark of *ta'neeth*:

Word	Huroof Asliyyah	Reason
سَمَاء	س م و	the final waw changed into a hamzah
مَاء	م و ه	the hamzah is in origin a substitute for haa'

In both these words the hamzah replaces a root letter; it is not a mark of *ta'neeth*. Such words are not feminine merely by their shape. It should be noted that the *Alif Mamdudah* as a mark of the feminine occurs in comparatively few Arabic words.

5.4 Alif Maqsurah

The *Alif Maqsurah* is a small alif generally written above a yaa', and sometimes over the letter preceding the yaa'. It usually comes at the end of nouns.

Rule: Any noun ending in an *Alif Maqsurah* that is additional to the *Huroof Asliyyah* and is not a substitute for a waw or a yaa' is counted feminine.

- كُبْرَى — the greatest (f.)
- عَطْشَى — thirsty (f.)
- ذِكْرَى — a reminder

6. The Sama'i Mu'annath

A *Sama'i Mu'annath* is one that native speakers use as feminine even though it carries no outward mark of the feminine. There is no rule by which to recognise these; they are known only by hearing and memorising. The chief groups are as follows.

Group	Examples
Names of winds	رِيحٌ، صَرْصَرٌ، سُمُومٌ، صَبَا، دُبُورٌ، شَمَالٌ
Names of wine	خَمْرٌ، خُرْطُومٌ
Names of fire and Hell	نَارٌ، جَهَنَّمٌ، جَحِيمٌ، سَعِيرٌ، سَقَرٌ
Names of cities and countries	مَكَّةُ، الْمَدِينَةُ، بَاكِسْتَان
Paired parts of the body	يَدٌ، قَدَمٌ، أُذُنٌ، عَيْنٌ، رُكْبَةٌ، سَاقٌ، عَقَبٌ
Names of the letters	أَلِفٌ، بَاءٌ، تَاءٌ

Group	Examples
Huroof ul Jarr	إِلَى ، عَلَى
Miscellaneous nouns	سَّمَاءٌ ، أَرْضٌ ، شَمْسٌ ، نَفْسٌ ، دَارٌ ، حَرْبٌ ، عَصَا ، بَيْتٌ ، كَأْسٌ ، فُلُكٌ
A few more	نَعْلٌ (shoe) ، أَفْعَى (snake) ، أَرْنَبٌ (hare) ، تَعْلَبٌ (fox)

A special point: The word سَّمَاء occurs in the Qur'an as both masculine and feminine, so it may be read and understood either way.

7. Nouns used as both Mudhakkar and Mu'annath

Some nouns are used by the Arabs as masculine and as feminine alike. A few of them are given below.

Word and meaning	Word and meaning
عُنُق (neck)	طَرِيق (road)
عَقِب (heel)	سَبِيل (way)
عُقَاب (eagle)	رُوح (soul)
عَنْكَبُوت (spider)	سِكِّين (knife)
لِسَان (tongue)	سُوق (market)
نَفْس (self)	سُلَّم (ladder)
حَال (state)	كَبِد (liver)
مِلْح (salt)	مِسْك (musk)
أَلْف (thousand)	فَأْس (axe)

Summary

1. Four aspects of any Ism must be known: gender, number, definiteness and I'raab.
2. A Mudhakkar carries no mark of ta'neeth; a Mu'annath is one in which such a mark is found.
3. In Arabic every Ism is taken as Mudhakkar until it is established as Mu'annath.
4. The mark of ta'neeth may be present in the word itself or only underlying it, as اَرْض shows through its diminutive اَرْضَة.
5. Living creatures have real gender, which stays the same in every language. Lifeless things have unreal gender, which varies from language to language.
6. مَسْجِد, كِتَاب and جِدَار are feminine in Urdu but Mudhakkar in Arabic; يَد, اَلْمَدِينَة, غُرْفَة and سَمَاء are masculine in Urdu but Mu'annath in Arabic.
7. The Mu'annath Haqeeqi covers three kinds of noun: those with a masculine counterpart, women's names, and nouns used only for women.
8. The Mu'annath Ghayr Haqeeqi is also called Majazi and Lafzi, and divides into 'Alamati (Qiyasi) and Sama'i.
9. There are three marks of ta'neeth: the Taa' Marbutah, the Alif Mamdudah and the Alif Maqsurah. The round ة is by far the most common.
10. اَخِيْفَة, طَلْحَة, خَدِيْفَة, اُسَامَة, عَلَامَة and خَلِيْفَة are masculine despite ending in a round ة.
11. About ninety percent of Arabic nouns rest on three letters, called the Huroof Asliyyah or Huroof ul Maddah.
12. The Alif Mamdudah is a mark of ta'neeth only when it is additional and its hamzah is not one of the Huroof Asliyyah, as in صَفْرَاء and صَحْرَاء.
13. In سَمَاء and مَاء the hamzah replaces a root letter, so the Alif Mamdudah there is not a mark of ta'neeth.
14. The Alif Maqsurah is likewise a mark of ta'neeth on condition of being additional, as in كُبْرَى, ذِكْرَى and عَطَشَى.
15. The chief groups of the Sama'i Mu'annath are winds, wine, fire and Hell, cities and countries, paired parts of the body, the letters, and the Huroof ul Jarr.

Exercise

1. Write the four aspects of an Ism and explain each briefly.
2. Define Mudhakkar and Mu'annath, and state which gender is taken as the default in Arabic.
3. Explain the difference between real and unreal gender with examples.
4. Write three nouns that are feminine in Urdu but Mudhakkar in Arabic, and three that are the reverse.
5. Write the three kinds of noun that fall under the Mu'annath Haqeeqi, with two examples of each.

6. Why is the Mu'annath Ghayr Haqeeqi also called Majazi and Lafzi? Give the reason for each name.
7. Write all three marks of ta'neeth with examples.
8. Write the five nouns that are masculine despite ending in a round ة.
9. What are the Huroof Asliyyah? Separate them out for صَالِح and مُنَافِق.
10. Both سَمَاء and صَحْرَاء end in an Alif Mamdudah, so why is one a mark of ta'neeth and the other not?
11. Write five groups of the Sama'i Mu'annath with two examples of each.
12. Write five nouns that are used as both Mudhakkar and Mu'annath.

سُبْحَانَكَ اللَّهُمَّ وَبِحَمْدِكَ، أَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا أَنْتَ، أَسْتَغْفِرُكَ وَأَتُوبُ إِلَيْكَ

اللَّهُمَّ صَلِّ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا صَلَّيْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ

اللَّهُمَّ بَارِكْ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا بَارَكْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ